

Chapter 4: Introduction to R

R for Descriptive Statistics

Gordon Wright

23 January 2026

Overview

This reading prepares you for the lab session where you'll use R to compute descriptive statistics. You don't need any prior programming experience — we'll use WebR, which runs directly in your browser.

What Is R?

R is a programming language designed for statistical analysis. It's:

- **Free and open-source** — anyone can use it
- **Powerful** — handles everything from simple means to complex models
- **Widely used** — the standard in psychology, biology, medicine, and data science
- **Reproducible** — your analysis is documented in code

Why Learn R?

Excel can calculate a mean. So why bother with R?

1. **Reproducibility:** R code documents exactly what you did. "I calculated the mean" becomes `mean(data$reaction_time)` — clear and precise.
2. **Efficiency:** Once written, code can be reused. Analyse one dataset, apply the same analysis to another.
3. **Capabilities:** R handles analyses that Excel simply cannot — bootstrapping, mixed models, complex visualisations.
4. **Transparency:** Sharing code lets others check your work. This is increasingly required in psychology journals.

WebR: R in Your Browser

We use **WebR** — R that runs entirely in your browser. No installation needed.

How It Works

When you see a code box like this:

```
mean(c(5, 10, 15, 20))
```

You can:

1. Click in the box
2. Press the “Run” button
3. See the output immediately

The code runs in your browser, not on a server. Your data stays on your machine.

R Basics for Today

You don’t need to master R today — just understand enough to follow along. Here are the essentials:

Assigning Values

Use `<-` (less-than followed by dash) to assign values:

```
# Store a value
my_score <- 75

# Store multiple values
reaction_times <- c(245, 312, 278, 298, 267)
```

The `c()` function combines values into a **vector** (a list of numbers).

Basic Functions

Functions do things. They have a name followed by parentheses containing inputs:

```
# Mean of values
mean(c(10, 20, 30))

# Sum of values
sum(c(10, 20, 30))

# Number of values
length(c(10, 20, 30))
```

Computing Descriptives

For descriptive statistics, you’ll use:

Function	What It Does
<code>mean(x)</code>	Arithmetic mean
<code>median(x)</code>	Median (middle value)

Function	What It Does
<code>sd(x)</code>	Standard deviation
<code>var(x)</code>	Variance
<code>min(x)</code>	Minimum value
<code>max(x)</code>	Maximum value
<code>range(x)</code>	Returns both min and max
<code>summary(x)</code>	Overview (min, quartiles, mean, max)

Example: Reaction Times

```
# Create data
rt <- c(245, 312, 278, 298, 267)

# Compute statistics
mean(rt)      # 280
median(rt)    # 278
sd(rt)        # 26.2
```

Understanding Output

When R gives you output, it includes some formatting. For example:

```
[1] 280
```

The `[1]` just means “first element.” For a single number, you can ignore it.

For longer output:

```
[1] 245 267 278 298 312
```

The numbers 245, 267, etc. are your data. The `[1]` tells you where the first element is.

Working with Data Frames

Real datasets aren’t just vectors — they’re **data frames** (like a spreadsheet with rows and columns).

Accessing Columns

Use `$` to access a column:

```
# If 'olympics' is your dataset
olympics$reaction_time # Get the reaction_time column
mean(olympics$reaction_time) # Mean of that column
```

Subsetting Data

Get specific parts of your data:

```
# Filter rows where room is "A"
room_a <- olympics[olympics$room == "A", ]

# Get mean reaction time for Room A only
mean(room_a$reaction_time)
```

Common Errors (And How to Fix Them)

Error: object 'x' not found

Meaning: R doesn't recognise that name.

Fixes:

- Check spelling (R is case-sensitive: Data ≠ data)
- Make sure you created the object first
- Run all code chunks in order

Error: could not find function "x"

Meaning: R doesn't recognise that function.

Fixes:

- Check spelling
- Some functions need packages (we'll load these for you)

Unexpected symbol error

Meaning: R found something it didn't expect.

Fixes:

- Check for missing commas or parentheses
- Make sure quotes match (both " or both ')

Preparing for the Lab

What You'll Do

In the lab, you'll:

1. Load the DataLab dataset
2. Explore the variables (columns)
3. Calculate means, medians, and SDs for different measures
4. Compare Room A vs Room B
5. Visualise distributions with histograms

Before You Arrive

- Read this page (you're doing that now!)
- Have the Lecture Reading fresh in mind
- Bring a laptop or phone (WebR runs in any modern browser)

What to Focus On

The goal isn't to memorise R syntax. Focus on:

- **What** each statistic tells you (meaning over mechanics)
- **How** the statistics relate to your DataLab experience
- **Why** we compute these particular measures

Key Terms

Term	Definition
R	Programming language for statistical analysis
WebR	R running in a web browser
Vector	A list of values of the same type
Data frame	A table with rows and columns
Function	Code that performs an action (like <code>mean()</code>)

Summary

What	How in R
Mean	<code>mean(x)</code>
Median	<code>median(x)</code>
SD	<code>sd(x)</code>
Access column	<code>data\$column</code>
Create vector	<code>c(1, 2, 3)</code>

Additional Resources

If you want to explore R further:

- R for Data Science — Free online textbook
- RStudio Primers — Interactive tutorials
- Quick-R — Syntax reference